

MAN IN CHARGE
Bihar CM Nitish Kumar in Patna on July 10

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HARD LESSONS

By Amitabh Srivastava

Bihar isn't much known for an abundance of education infrastructure—an endemic scarcity is more like it. Even so, preliminary findings from an official scrutiny of 80,000 state government schools have come as a shocker. Especially the fact that Rs 1,400 crore school funds have been sitting unutilised. Principals have the mandate to take up development work of up to Rs 5 lakh for their schools. But what the survey ran into was systemic inertia: minutiae like missing bulbs, dingy toilets and unused lab equipment adding up to a sorry big picture. Sorrier for the fact that, under Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, education usually gets top billing—in this year's Rs 2.62 lakh crore budget, it was endowed with the highest outlay of Rs 40,450 crore.

In the backdrop, there's a story of conflict. Since 2022, the education portfolio has been held by Madhepura MLA Chandra Shekhar of the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD), who made his mark by stirring up a storm with remarks on the *Ramcharitmanas*. But in June, Nitish hand-picked 1990 batch IAS officer K.K. Pathak to be the department's additional chief secretary—and friction has clouded proceedings ever since. After taking charge, Pathak launched sweeping measures that parents largely welcomed: a GPS-enabled attendance system, Google Sheets to record the number of students present for mid-day meals, regular school inspections.

But it took just a month for things to turn ugly. Not only did teachers start getting irked by the 'interference', Chandra Shekhar himself complained about being kept out of the loop. On July 4, his personal secretary, Krishna Nand Yadav, shot off letters to Pathak and other officers to convey the minister's displeasure. The officials hit back, rubbishing the allegations and banning Yadav's entry into their offices. As the controversy snowballed, Nitish himself had to intervene. He met the two warring officials separately, advising them to resolve issues amicably. But the unprecedented 'letter war' had by then exposed chinks in the Janata Dal (United)-RJD tie-up.

Since 2005, when Nitish took over as Bihar CM for his first full term, education had been JD(U) territory almost all through. His initiatives—from teacher recruitment to free books, uniforms and bicycles—had been a key part of his reform persona. But in August 2022, he ceded the crucial department to his alliance partner. Chandra Shekhar's tenure so far has produced more heat than light: besides the *Ramcharitmanas* row, the minister has frequently put the alliance government in a tight spot in other ways too, not the least by sparring with aspiring teachers and reportedly calling them incompetent.

Pathak, said to be close to Nitish, was meant to be a cure. "He has a brief to make the education system functional," says a senior IAS officer. In May, the state cabinet had approved a proposal to recruit 178,000 teachers and Nitish needed a competent hand at the wheel.

For now, RJD boss Lalu Yadav has backed Nitish. In a meeting, Lalu and his son, deputy CM Tejashwi Yadav, told partymen to "forget small issues" and focus on the big battle: the Lok Sabha election. The gist was—let Nitish run the show, and say nothing that could benefit the BJP or weaken the Mahagathbandhan government. "Some overenthusiastic RJD leaders had been trying to paint this as a battle between the CM's handpicked officer and Tejashwi's minister. Lalu's message to them is nothing less than a final word," says a senior JD(U) leader. The school of politics still has uses for the old master. ■

LALU HAD TO CHIDE RESTIVE PARTYMEN TO END A FACEOFF BETWEEN THE RJD'S EDUCATION MINISTER AND THE CM'S MAN